



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times
PEOPLE on rides in August at the Humboldt County Fair, which has lost \$430,000 to theft.

A TIMES INVESTIGATION

CORRUPTION, THEFT RIFE AT COUNTY FAIRS

Accountability lacking in festivals across the state

By Jessica Garrison | REPORTING FROM FERNDALE, CALIF.

Like many of California’s fairs, the one in Humboldt County is a cherished local institution, beloved for its junk food, adorable baby animals and exhibits of local arts and crafts. Rock star chef Guy Fieri, who grew up in town, even turns up to host the chili cook-off.

But along with its Ferris wheels and funnel cakes, the Humboldt County event shares something darker in common with a number of California’s 77 local fairs: It has been racked with fraud and mismanagement.

The fair’s former bookkeeper is due in federal court early next year after pleading guilty to stealing \$430,000 from the fair, according to documents filed in federal court. Police had arrested her after catching up with her at a local casino.

Humboldt is hardly an outlier. A Los Angeles Times investigation has found that one-third of the state’s 77 fairs — hallowed celebrations of the

state’s agrarian tradition — have been plagued by an array of problems. Workers from at least four fairs have been prosecuted in the last few years for theft, bribery or embezzlement, with more than \$1 million stolen, according to a Times review of criminal court filings. State auditors have accused officials at dozens of other fairs of mispending millions more, according to a Times review. Ventura was a victim of a cash heist, Santa Clara a kickback scheme, and across much of California, public funds have been spent in violation of state rules, including on prime rib steaks and fancy wines while once-proud fairgrounds crumble into disrepair.

Proud on thousands of pages of court filings, audits and public records from more than three dozen counties, along with scores of interviews, The Times identified at least 25 fairs where prosecutors, state auditors or government officials have [See Fairs, A10]

AT LEAST 2 KILLED, 8 INJURED IN CAMPUS SHOOTING

Gunman is at large after attack at Brown University. Survivors in critical condition.

By KIMBERLEE KRUESI,
JENNIFER McDERMOTT
AND ALANNA
DURKIN RICHER

PROVIDENCE, R.I. — A gunman dressed in black killed at least two people and wounded eight others at Brown University on Saturday during final exams on the Ivy League campus in Rhode Island, authorities said as police searched for the suspect.

Officers were hunting through campus buildings and sifting through trash cans more than three hours after the shooting erupted.

The suspect is a male who was wearing dark clothing and was last seen leaving the building, said Timothy O’Hara, deputy chief of police in Providence, where Brown is located.

Providence Mayor Brett Smiley said a shelter-in-place order was in effect for the area and encouraged people living near the campus to stay inside and not to return home until it is lifted.

“We have all available resources” to find the suspect, Smiley said.

The eight wounded people were in critical but stable condition, the mayor said. [See Shooting, A8]

Young hiker still lost on Whitney

His family has made desperate appeals on social media for help

By Jack Dolan



JOSEPH BRAMBILA
SEARCHES for Joseph Brambila, who set off two days after his 21st birthday, have been fruitless.

Towering granite spires whiz by in the background, and Joseph Brambila howls with delight, in a YouTube video he shot of himself sliding on his butt down a steep, snowy slope on the upper reaches of Mt. Whitney.

When he loses control and wipes out — repeatedly — it looks like he’s tumbling inside a snow globe.

He has none of the usual safety equipment for such a slide, known to mountaineers as a “glissade”: no helmet and, crucially, no ice ax, which is used as a brake to avoid picking up too much speed and hurtling into a catastrophic fall.

But he’s lucky. It’s a warm, sunny day in June and the snow is so forgiving he can stop by simply digging his heels into the soft slush.

Even so, while drying his clothes in the sun at the bottom of the 1,500-foot slope, the charming, slightly mischievous 20-year-old confesses to his camera, “Low key, I didn’t know how that was going to turn out. Half of it was good and then way too much speed.” [See Hiker, A9]

A deluge of podcasts, hosted by AI

By NILESH CHRISTOPHER

Chatty bots are sharing their hot takes through hundreds of thousands of AI-generated podcasts. And the invasion has just begun.

Though their banter can be a bit banal, the AI podcasters’ confidence and research are now arguably better than most people’s.

“We’ve just begun to cross the threshold of voice AI being pretty much indistinguishable from human,” said Alan Cowen, chief executive of Hume AI, a startup specializing in voice technol-

ogy. “We’re seeing creators use it in all kinds of ways.”

AI can make podcasts sound better and cost less, industry insiders say, but the growing swarm of new competitors entering an already crowded market is disrupting the industry.

Some podcasters are pushing back, requesting restrictions. Others are already cloning their voices and handing over their podcasts to AI bots.

Popular podcast host Steven Bartlett has used an AI clone to launch a new kind of content aimed at the 13 million followers of his

podcast “Diary of a CEO.” On YouTube, his clone narrates “100 CEOs With Steven Bartlett,” which adds AI-generated animation to Bartlett’s cloned voice to tell the life stories of entrepreneurs such as Steve Jobs and Richard Branson.

Erica Mandy, the Redondo Beach-based host of the daily news podcast “The Newsworthy,” let an AI voice fill in for her earlier this year after she lost her voice from laryngitis and her backup host bailed out.

She fed her script into a text-to-speech model and [See AI podcasts, A16]

‘Fraudulent’ UC probes cited in DOJ departures

Lawyers in antisemitism cases say they quit over lapses in standards

By JAWEED KALEEM

Nine former Department of Justice attorneys assigned to investigate alleged antisemitism at the University of California described chaotic and rushed directives from the Trump administration and told The Times they felt pressured to conclude that campuses had violated the civil rights of Jewish students and staff.

In interviews over several weeks, the career attorneys — who together served dozens of years — said they were given the instructions at the onset of the investigations. All nine attorneys resigned during the course of their UC assignments, some concerned that they were being asked to violate ethical standards.

“Initially we were told we only had 30 days to come up with a reason to be ready to sue UC,” said Ejaz Baluch, a former senior trial attorney who was assigned to investigate whether Jewish UCLA

faculty and staff faced discrimination on campus that the university did not properly address. “It shows just how unserious this exercise was. It was not about trying to find out what really happened.”

In spring 2024, increasingly tumultuous protests over Israel’s war in Gaza racked UCLA. Jewish students and faculty reported “broad-based perceptions of antisemitic and anti-Israeli bias on campus,” a UCLA antisemitism task force found. A group later sued, charging that UCLA violated their civil rights, and won millions of dollars and concessions in a settlement.

UCLA avoided trial, but the suit — along with articles from conservative websites such as the Washington Free Beacon — formed a basis for the UC investigations, the former DOJ lawyers said.

“UCLA came the closest to having possibly broken the law in how it responded or treated civil rights com- [See DOJ, A8]

Will Democrats bet on California?

As Harris, Newsom step up, age-old perils and promises of the state are at forefront.

By SEEMA MEHTA
AND DAKOTA SMITH

California’s potential to lead a national Democratic comeback was on full display as party leaders from across the country recently gathered in downtown Los Angeles.

But is the party ready to bet on the Golden State?

Appearances at the Democratic National Committee meeting by the state’s most prominent Democrats, former Vice President Kamala Harris and Gov. Gavin Newsom, crystallized the peril and promise of California’s appeal. Harris failed to beat a politically wounded Donald Trump in the 2024

presidential race and Newsom, now among President Trump’s most celebrated critics, is considered a top Democratic contender to replace the Republican president in the White House in 2028.

California policies on divisive issues such as providing expanded access to government-sponsored health care, aiding undocumented immigrants and supporting LGBTQ+ rights continually serve as a Rorschach test for the nation’s polarized electorate, providing comfort to progressives and ammunition for Republican attack ads.

“California is like your cool cousin that comes for the holidays who is intriguing and glamorous, but who might not fit in with the family year-round,” said Elizabeth Ashford, a veteran Democratic strategist who worked for former Govs. [See Democrats, A13]



101 BEST RESTAURANTS

Our annual dining guide is included in today’s newspaper for print subscribers. It is also available for purchase at latimes.com/store.

3 Americans killed in Syria

Trump vows retaliation after ambush blamed on Islamic State kills and injures U.S. service members. **WORLD, A4**

Weather

Early clouds, then sun. L.A. Basin: 79/52. **B8**

Business **A15**
Opinion Voices **A18**

The pop culture favorites of 2025

A roundup of the year’s top picks in TV, music, movies, theater, comedy, art and books. **ENTERTAINMENT**

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